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Library Column: Pokemon Club at Moscow Library

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The Moscow Library now has a weekly Pokemon Club. For those of you who don't know, Pokemon is a trading card game based on a Japanese TV show and video game series that has been around since 1996 in Japan and came to the U.S. in 1999. In order to explain what Pokemon is all about, I enlisted my daughter, Persephone, to help me write this column.

I've been playing in the Moscow Pokemon League since 2007. Until February, we had been meeting at a local business but we had to stop meeting there for a bunch of reasons. When we had to stop meeting there my friends and I didn't have anywhere to play, so I decided to try to start a league at the Moscow Library because they are open Saturday and that's when we met at the old place. Meeting at the library also made sense because my dad and Jacki Fulwood, the youth services manager, work there and liked the idea of having a Pokemon league. We've been meeting there since April and we usually have 3-6 people show up but we'd like to have more people come. We meet 2-4 p.m. in the Brink Room at the Moscow library, and anyone 8 and older is invited to come play.

I've played in leagues and tournaments in Spokane and Seattle, but most of the time I play in Moscow because it's so close to home. Playing Pokemon allows you to learn strategic thinking and, since the game requires a lot of reading, some addition and subtraction as well as some organizational skills. It's a really good way for younger kids to learn ideas that might help them in other parts of their life.

In order to play the Pokemon trading card game you have to organize a 60-card

deck that has a balance of character cards, energy cards, trainer cards and other special cards so that you can win "battles" with other players. And the people you're playing against have to do the same things, so really half of winning at Pokemon happens when you create your Pokemon deck - and luck. You need lots and lots of luck.

Playing Pokemon is fun because it's more fun and relaxed than other trading card games. Pokemon allows you to play with and become friends with other people. For me it's more about friendship than the actual game that makes Pokemon fun.

So if you have a kid who is interested in playing Pokemon at the Moscow Library and have any questions, please call the Moscow Library at (208) 882-3925 and we can get you some more information. And if you know someone who doesn't have any Pokemon cards but would still like to give it a try, Persephone has "loaner" decks available every Saturday afternoon and is really good at teaching people the ins and outs of the game.

George Williams is Access Services manager for the Latah County Library District. **Persephone Williams**, 15, is a Troy High School student and frequent volunteer at the Moscow branch of the Latah County Library District.

